The atmosphere soured further at the third SED conference in March 1956, when those hoping Ulbricht would tackle the issue of the Khrushchev speech, and interpret what it meant for them, were left bitterly disappointed. Instead, he was ambivalent and evasive and launched into lectures on everything ranging from transport to corn cultivation, prompting several participants to walk out.

In an awkward effort to find a point of agreement, Ulbricht approved the establishment of a ‘Commission for the Review of Matters of Former Party Members’ to examine the ‘unjustified persecution’ of SED comrades in the late 40s and early 1950s. At the time, around 13,000 people were serving sentences in East German jails for ‘crimes against the state’. Soon after, as a gesture of conciliation, seventy-three SED members were rescued from official obscurity, including Anton Ackermann, Elli Schmidt and Hans Jendretzky. Ulbricht’s biggest concession was granting pardons and early releases to 11,896 others. By the end of 1956, nearly 21,000 people had been released.